



For the Right Choice

An established trend in the West, professional shopping is catching on in India where buyers want value for their money

Money does buy class in the new India. It gets you anything—from a Cartier watch to a Lamborghini Gallardo Spyder. It dresses you up in Prada and makes you apply just the right touch of Chanel No 5. But what it doesn't really do is help you bring all these together in one sophisticated package. So, if you really don't know what designer clothes suit you, use a bit more of that money and hire a professional shopper. An established phenomenon in the West, the professional shopper in India is just making an appearance. They call themselves anything—from a stylist to a shopping assistant, who opine on your every expensive purchase.

With a potential luxury goods and service market of Rs 65,000 crore, according to a KSA-Technopark survey conducted in 2006, professional shopping is an emerging trend in India. Currently, a number of online agencies, mostly operating out of the US, cater to tourists visiting India and promise to assist them in the country,

since street shopping here can be a risky proposition. Most brands which own stores in India now have shopping consultants who not only advise the client what to buy from their store, but also provide a complete shopping experience. Anu Shyamsundar, a designer with a company based in Chennai, recalls how industrialist Vijay Mallya had once walked into their store and decided to buy a pair of cargos. "To assist a client like him, we have a person to work on a number of aspects, like customised fitting and product assistance," she recalls. When

PRO AT BUYING: Bhatia (right) has made an entire career out of advising people what to wear and carry

Van Heusen launched its women's wear line some years ago, it provided shopping assistance to its customers to create a complete look. But the trouble with such brand-based professional shopping is that the customer only gets to choose from a limited range of items made available by the brand. Which is why there is an increasing demand for shopping advisors who are neither designers nor are connected with any particular brand.

The trend has given fillip to the likes of Namrata G. Bhatia who have made an entire career out of advising people what to wear. "We make sure we have the complete confidence of the client. The process takes three to six months depending on the need for the change," she says.

And the result? "There are cases where people have got promotions and newly married brides have been accepted in their new homes," says Bhatia, who has now started an institute called CorPretFox where she trains students on custom buying and styling. "Professional shopping is getting bigger and bigger in India," says Delhi-based stylist Gautam Kalra, "only, it needs to be more organised to be called an industry." **by Swagata Sen**

SHOPPERS STOP

- Consultants advise the client what to buy from their store.
- Help the client to match and accessorise their wardrobe.
- Use their contacts to get access to new collections.
- Charge a fee for their service.